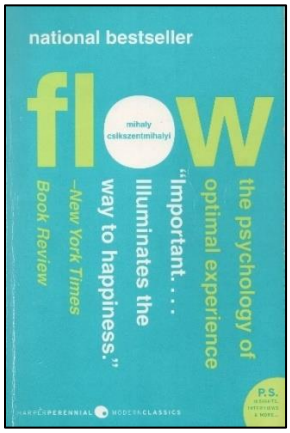
Flow: The Psychology of Optimal Experience (1990)

Mihalyi Czikszentmihaliyi (1934-2021)



Introduction

I love this book. What follows are the ideas I found inspirational, entertaining, and educational. This summary is comprised of direct quotes from the book (followed by page number). I've occasionally interspersed personal reflections and comments (in italics). Every one of the book's 280 pages has important data but since I can't reproduce the whole book I've arranged topics in alphabetical order. The book does not have an index so I made my own. Enjoy. Note: writing this paper put me in the state of flow!

Attention

"The most important step in emancipating oneself from social controls is the ability to find rewards in the events of each moment." 19

"It is attention that selects the relevant bits of information from the potential millions of bits available. It takes attention to retrieve the appropriate references from memory, to evaluate the event, and then to choose the right thing to do." 31. *This is good news for those with ADD. They're not incapable of focusing on data, a diagnosis which carries a stigma. It's their inability to ferret out relevant data from stimulation overload. They pay too much attention to too many things, which is a less pejorative assessment.*

"The mark of a person who is in control of consciousness is the ability to focus attention at will, to be oblivious to distractions, to concentrate for as long as it takes to achieve a goal, and not longer." 31

"When all a person's relevant skills are needed to cope with the challenges of a situation, that person's attention is completely absorbed by the activity…. concentration is very complete." 53

Boredom

"For those who don't have the right skills, the activity is not challenging; it is simply meaningless." 50

"Everybody develops routines to fill in the boring gaps of the day, or to bring experience back on an even keel when anxiety threatens. Some people are compulsive doodlers..." 52

"The less skilled player will feel anxious, and the better player will feel bored." 52

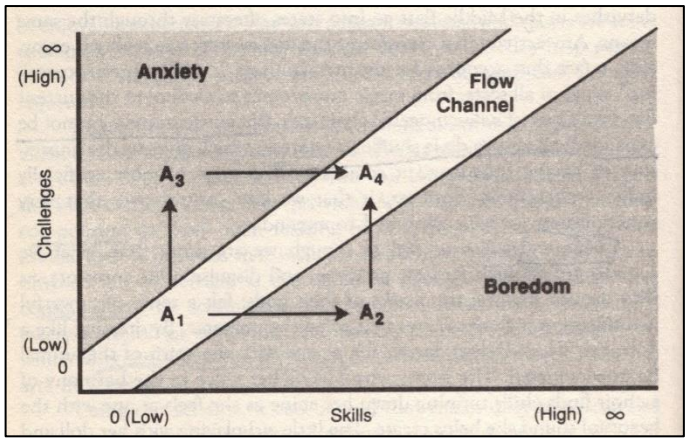
"…life passes in a sequence of boring and anxious experiences over which a person has little control." 69

"Much of what we label juvenile delinquency—car theft, vandalism, rowdy behavior in general—is motivated by the same need to have flow experiences not available in ordinary life." 69. *Bingo! I never stole a car and my vandalism was petty, but much of my misspent youth was motivated by boredom avoidance.*

"When the doldrums set in, they might go to heroic lengths to find any challenge at all." 175

"How could one ever be bored with so many good things to see and feel!" 205. *A Hebrew sage wrote, "The eyes of a person are never filled." I concur. My eyes have been absorbing sights for seven decades and they're not even close to being filled.*

Chart



This is the heart of the book. To move from A2 to A4 one must increase challenges. To move from A3 to A4 one must increase skills.

"…enjoyment depends on increasing complexity." 149

"When there are too many demands, options, challenges, we become anxious; when too few, we get bored." 228

Controlling Thoughts

"No great improvements in the lot of mankind are possible, until a great change takes place in the fundamental constitution of their modes of thought," John Stuart Mill, 9

"…we can transform reality to the extent that we influence what happens in consciousness and thus free ourselves from the threats and blandishments of the outside world." 20

"…control of consciousness determines the quality of life…" 20

"Control over consciousness is not simply a cognitive skill. At least as much as intelligence, it requires the commitment of emotions and will." 21

"…consciousness must be reformulated every time the culture context changes." 21

"Any small gain in that direction [thought control] will make life more rich, more enjoyable, more meaningful." 22

"…it seems that those who take the trouble to gain mastery over what happens in consciousness do live happier lives." 23

"…it is possible to process at most 126 bits of information per second, or 7,560 per minute, or almost half a million per hour." 29

"When a person is able to organize his or her consciousness so as to experience flow as often as possible, the quality of life is inevitably going to improve…" 40

"The concentration of the flow experience—together with clear goals and immediate feedback—provides order to consciousness, inducing the enjoyable condition of psychic negrentropy." 59. *There's a word you don't hear every day, "negentropy." It means slowing down or reversing entropy, nature's move from order to disorder.*

"Some of the most exhilarating experiences we undergo are generated inside the mind, triggered by information that challenges our ability to think…" 117

"But when we are left alone, with no demands on attention, the basic disorder of the mind reveals itself. With nothing to do, it begins to follow random patterns, usually stopping to consider something painful or disturbing. Unless a person knows how to give order to his or her thoughts, attention will be attracted to whatever is most problematic at the moment: it will focus on some real or imaginary pain, on recent grudges or long-term frustrations. Entropy is the normal state of consciousness—a condition that is neither useful nor enjoyable." 119

Flow

"[Flow] begins with achieving control over the contents of our consciousness." 2. *This is the basis of cognitive therapy.*

"…people who have survived concentration camps or who have lived through near-fatal physical dangers often recall that in the midst of their ordeal they experienced extraordinarily rich epiphanies in response to such simple events as hearing the song of a bird in the forest, completing a hard task, or sharing a crust of bread with a friend." 3.

"The best moments usually occur when a person's body or mind is stretched to its limits in a voluntary effort to accomplish something difficult and worthwhile." 3.

"I developed a theory of optimal experience based on the concept of *flow*—the state in which people are so involved in any activity that nothing else seems to matter; the experience itself is so enjoyable that people will do it even at great cost, for the sheer sake of doing it." 4.

"The concept of flow has been found useful by psychologists who study happiness, life satisfaction, and intrinsic motivation; by sociologists who see in it the opposite of anomie and alienation; by anthropologists who are interested in collective effervescence and rituals." 5.

"The optimal state of inner experience is one in which there is order in consciousness. This happens when psychic energy—or attention—is invested in realistic goals, and when skills match the opportunities for action." 6.

"Even the most humdrum experiences become enjoyable." 7.

"Such individuals [people in flow] lead vigorous lives, are open to a variety of experiences, keep on learning until they day they die and have strong ties and commitments to other people and to the environment in which they live. They enjoy whatever they do, even if tedious or difficult; they are hardly ever bored, and they can take in stride anything that comes their way." 10. *The phrase "taking in stride" reflects a sixth century BCE Greek philosophy called Stoicism. I'm a fan.*

"Genuinely happy individuals are few and far between. How many people do you know who enjoy what they're doing, are reasonably satisfied with their lot, who do not regret the past and look to the future with genuine confidence?" 11

"Any small gain in that direction will make life more rich, more enjoyable, more meaningful." 22

"But anyone who has experienced flow knows that the deep enjoyment it provides requires an equal degree of disciplines concentration." 41. *As an adult I self-diagnosed my child/teen self with a mild case of "attention deficit disorder." This explains why I find the concept of flow so compelling. Once you get the hang of disciplined concentration the result is delish!*

"One of the most frequently mentioned dimensions of the flow experience is that, while it lasts, one is able to forget all the unpleasant aspects of life." 58

"[Flow] provided a sense of discovery, a creative feeling of transporting the person into a new reality." 74. *Who needs drugs to expand reality when one can experience a "new reality" naturally?*

"Lost in Antarctica or confined to a prison cell, some individuals succeed in transforming their harrowing conditions into a manageable and even enjoyable struggle, whereas most others would succumb the ordeal." 90. *This explains in part why being quarantined during the Covid pandemic was not onerous to me. I spent months in isolation doing things I enjoy such as decluttering, letting my beard grow, writing, drawing, rationing food, gardening, etc.*

"… a person who knows how to find flow from life is able to enjoy even situations that seem to allow only despair." 193. *This quote reminds me of the Hebrew saying, "A cheerful heart has a continual feast." Proverbs 15:15*

"The essential steps in this process are: (a) to set an overall goal, and as many subgoals as are realistically feasible; (b) to find ways of measuring progress in terms of the goals chosen; (c) to

keep concentrating on what one is doing and to keep making finer and finer distinctions in the challenges involved in the activity; (d) to develop the skills necessary to interact with the opportunities available; and (e) to keep raising the stakes if the activity becomes boring." 97. *Such a simple plan, so doable. Wish I'd thought of it!*

"The way to grow while enjoying life is to create a higher form of order out of the entropy that is an inevitable condition of living." 172. *This sounds strangely reminiscent of the command in Genesis to "subdue the earth, name animals, tend gardens, etc." Hebrew sages knew that imposing order on chaos was fulfilling.*

"What counts is to set a goal, to concentrate one's psychic energy, to pay attention to the feedback, and to make certain that the challenge is appropriate to one's skill." 190-1

"The outcome of having an autotelic [directed from within] self—of learning to set goals, to develop skills, to be sensitive to feedback, to know how to concentrate and get involved—is that one can enjoy life even when circumstances are brutish and nasty." 212-213

"If goals are well chosen, and if we have the courage to abide by them despite opposition, we shall be so focused on the actions and events around us that we don't have time to be unhappy." 227

Happiness

"…a joyful life cannot be copied from a recipe." xi

"Happiness is a condition that must be prepared for, cultivated, and defended privately by each person," Viktor Frankl 2

"Happiness…is the unintended side-effect of one's personal dedication to a course greater than oneself." 2

"However well intentioned, books cannot give recipes for how to be happy. Because optimal experience depends on the ability to control what happens in consciousness moment by moment, each person has to achieve it on the basis of his own individual efforts and creativity." 5

"Pleasure is a feeling of contentment that one achieves whenever information in consciousness says that expectations set by biological programs or by social conditioning have been met." 45

"I enjoy the clash of wits involved in bargaining…" 47

Job satisfaction

"Many people feel that the time they spend at work is essentially wasted—they are alienated from it, and the psychic energy invested in the job does nothing to strengthen their self." 68

"…by the same token even one exception [to the claim that all work is drudgery] is sufficient to disprove the notion that work must always be less enjoyable than freely chosen leisure." 147. *Having been indoctrinated with notions of "depravity" and "curses" I find Csikszentmihalyi's approach refreshing.*

"American workers tend to mention three main reasons for their dissatisfaction with their jobs…. lack of variety and change…conflicts with other people…burnout. …. These can be addressed by a subjective shift in one's consciousness." 161

Meaning

"I shall argue that the primary reason it is so difficult to achieve happiness centers on the fact that, contrary to the myths mankind has developed to reassure itself, the universe was not created to answer our needs." 7. *Religionists will take exception to this statement but it resonates with me.*

"…each person must use whatever tools are available to carve out a meaningful, enjoyable life…To achieve such autonomy, a person has to learn to provide rewards to herself." 16. *This makes sense. Rather than "discovering" meaning, I prefer "making" meaning.*

"It is true that life has no meaning, if by that we mean a supreme goal built into the fabric of nature and human experience, a goal that is valid for every individual. But it does not follow that life cannot be given meaning. Much of what we call culture and civilization consists in efforts people have made, generally against overwhelming odds, to create a sense of purpose for themselves and their descendants. It is one thing to accept this with resignation. The first fact does not entail the second any more that the fact that we lack wings prevents us from flying." 215. *I was weaned on the Westminster Confession of Faith which says there is* one *purpose for humanity. I like Csikszentmihalyi's way better.*

Misfortune

"Many lives are disrupted by tragic accidents, and even the most fortunate are subjected to stresses of various kinds. Yet such blows do not necessarily diminish happiness. It is how people respond to stress that determines whether they will profit form misfortune or be miserable." 7

"It seems that every time a pressing danger is avoided, a new and more sophisticated thereat appears on the horizon." 8

"…those who seek consolation in existing churches often pay for their peace of mind with a tacit agreement to ignore a great deal of what is known about the way the world works." 14.

"…transform hopeless situations into challenges." 24

"How does it come about that the same blow will destroy one person, while another will transform it into inner order?" 198. *Csikszentmihaliy's answer is what he calls coping ability, "the*

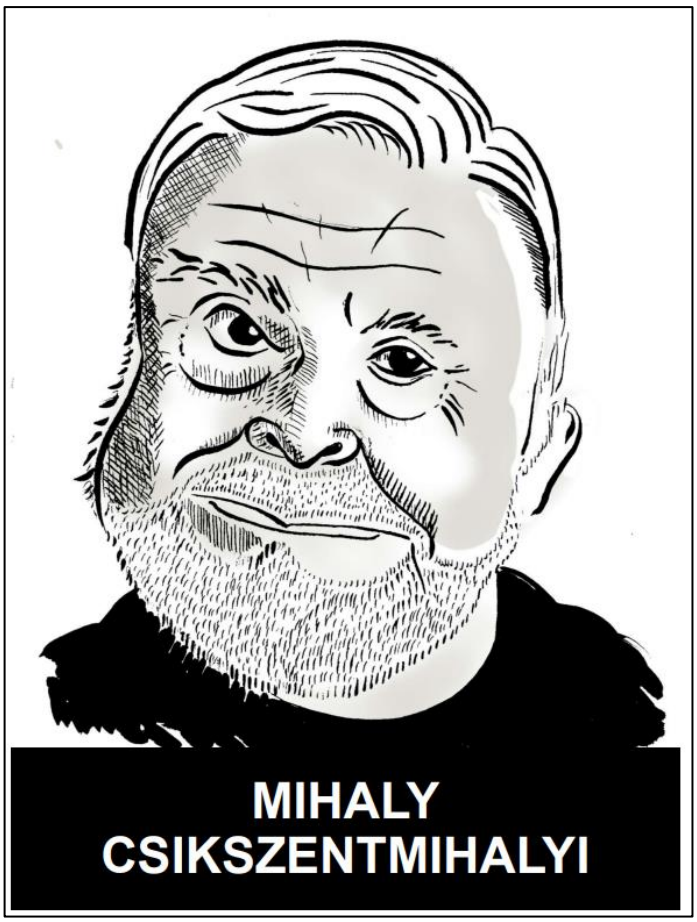
tendency of certain people to respond to threats by transforming them into manageable challenges..[also known as] hardiness." 276

"But what matters is not the trauma per se; the external event never determines what the theme will be. What matters is the interpretation that one places on the suffering. "233. *After years of scouring theodicies trying to explain how an omnibenevolent, omniscient, and omnipotent deity can coexist with unnecessary suffering I'm happy to report that Csikszentmihalyi's approach fits best.*

Subjectivity

"But increasingly the emphasis has been to value behavior over subjective states,; what is admired is success, achievement, the quality of the performance rather than the quality of the experience." 140. *This rings true. Another way to say it, "It's the journey, not the destination." When efficiency is all matters we tell the joke, "If Michelangelo could have finished the ceiling of the Sistine Chapel if he'd used a roller."*

"Subjective experience is not just one of the dimensions of life, it is life itself. Material conditions are secondary; they only affect us indirectly, by way of experience." 192



Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi (1934-2021). Hungarian psychologist. He recognized and named the psychological concept of flow, a highly focused mental state.

"I tend to trust ancient beliefs about good and bad, the sacred and profane, the meaningful and the worthless--not because they are amenable to proof but because they have been selected over time and in different situations and therefore might be worthy of belief."

Quoted in John Bockman,
What We Believe but Cannot Prove,
page 252.